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Politic**



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Russia's
Abduction
of Ukrainian
Children

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Dear readers,

We are so excited and honored to share Issue IV, the first publication from the 2026-2027 Managing Board. In this edition, we dive head-first into the most challenging issues we face today, both domestic and abroad.

David Dumontet opens with a gripping exploration of generational gang violence, drawing on the testimony of a family that escaped El Salvador's devastation, only to find it in Los Angeles.

Next, Eleanor Belinfanti explores the gig economy, focusing on workers challenged by the increasingly salient economic model, whose central promise — flexibility — ends up undermining those it was meant to benefit.

Our cover story, written by Diana Razumova, offers a raw and meticulous investigation into Russia's systematic abduction of Ukrainian children. Bringing in first-person accounts and expertise from international humanitarian actors, Razumova documents the continued devastation of the Russia-Ukraine War: the families separated, the children lost.

Turning to one of the most pressing contemporary crises, Floris Brocklebank presents a compelling account of the Strait of Hormuz—its history, its strategic importance, and how the war with Iran will transform the global energy landscape.

Melissa Adamantidi investigates the misuse of artificial intelligence to perpetuate sexual abuse. Through conversations with legal scholars, students, and teachers, Adamantidi explores the government's shortcomings and captures the tension at the core of this debate: balancing civil liberties and personal safety.

Finally, we turn to Argentina under President Milei. Rodrigo Cáceres Albuquerque offers a comprehensive analysis of how Milei was able to navigate a divided and frustrated political landscape to later transform the country's economy and social institutions. Paired with photography from Martín Zavala, the piece dives into Milei's Administration, highlighting the continued challenges the country faces.

For the first issue of the 2025-2026 Board, we wanted to showcase articles at the heart of The Politic style: deeply investigative, turning our attention to worldwide crises and domestic issues, bringing into focus the people behind the headlines. We hope you enjoy exploring these human stories as much as we did.

Warmly,
Pola, Hanna, Brandon,
Kushan, Sheena, and Suren
The 2026-2027 Managing Board

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La Sangre de Los Angeles

Testimony of MS-13 and Transnational Gang Violence from El Salvador to Los Angeles

BY DAVID DUMONTET

Orbelina shared her story at considerable personal risk. Some names and identifying details have been changed to protect her and her family's safety. Orbelina's interview was conducted in Spanish and translated.

April, 1985. San Salvador. Orbelina, seventeen, stood at the airport gate. Her mother held her face in her hands for the last time. She said:

"If you look back, you'll want to stay. I prefer 1,000 times that you live, even if I never see you again, than that you die here in the streets of El Salvador."

Orbelina lost her mother behind a veil of tears as she walked to her plane. The air was thick with tropical humidity and the soot of a country burning. Behind her, a war raged with no end in sight. Ahead stood a city she had never seen. She kept her eyes forward.

Orbelina's voice carries the testimony of several generations. She is one of many witnesses to the trail of blood, La Sangre de Los Angeles, leading from El Salvador to Los Angeles.

El Salvador's 13-year civil war ended in 1992 with the Chapultepec Peace Accords. Fighting between the United States-backed military government and the leftist guerrilla coalition Farabundo Martí National Liberation Front (FMLN) had torn the country apart.

There were all the trappings of successful diplomacy: formal delegations, in-

ternational witnesses, and the weight and pomp of ceremony. Peace accords signed in name only.

The FMLN entered "democratic" life as statesmen and law enforcement. The party of U.S.-backed oligarchs, Alianza Republicana Nacionalista (ARENA), retained its hold on the country's institutions.

"If you look back, you'll want to stay. I prefer 1,000 times that you live, even if I never see you again, than that you die here in the streets of El Salvador."

But the structural conditions that produced the war remained: extreme inequality, institutional violence, and a generation of young men with no path forward. The United Nations-backed Truth Commission documented the realities of the war, detailing massacres and disappearances of civilians carried out by U.S.-trained military units, and the organized state-sponsored murder of priests, students, and social activists by aptly titled Esquadrones de la Muerte, Death Squads.

The report listed names. It pointed to the highest levels of government and implicated both sides of the war.

But within days of its publication, the ARENA-controlled legislature passed a blanket amnesty law. No one was prosecuted. The victims received nothing: no acknowledgment, no reparations, no justice.

Orbelina's own father was assassinated by the FMLN on June 15, 1980, Father's Day, in front of her four half-brothers and his wife. His grave is unmarked. His killers were never named.

A hollowed-out country, El Salvador was traumatized and structurally devastated. Orbelina, like hundreds of thousands of Salvadorans, fled to America. It was an exodus of one-third of the Salvadoran population. Orbelina's generation was forced to flee. Raised in the smoldering embers of war, they left carrying wounds that would never fully close. Most never went back.

This generation did not disappear. They arrived in the Pico-Union neighborhood of central Los Angeles.

Graffiti and tags popped up overnight between the alleyways of dense, low-rise apartments. Packed ten to a room were thousands of Salvadoran refugees, nearly all without immigration papers. By the 1990s, 72% of the population in Pico-Union was foreign-born, and 51.2% was under 17.

Established Mexican-American and African-American gangs had already divided the neighborhood into a battlefield. Those who ran from war found themselves re-subjugated by armed gangs and territorial violence. Except now, over 2,700 miles away from home, they had no settled



LAPD Officer holds car theft suspects at gunpoint, later identified as gang members.
Los Angeles, 1994 (Photo: Joseph Rodriguez).

community, effectively no understanding of the language, little to no education, no protection, and dwindling hope.

All quickly became victims or, in time, participants.

Through the 80s into the early 90s, at the height of the crack cocaine epidemic and amid deep cuts to social services, greater Los Angeles had more than 60 Latino street gangs. Structural economic conditions and ineffective law enforcement permitted their proliferation; soon, there were entire communities that the city decided to contain rather than support. Controlling territory block-by-block, taxing drug sales, running extortion schemes, and making entire parts of the city impassable, gangs became the de facto governing force in neighborhoods the state abandoned.

One of the most infamous gangs was Mara Salvatrucha, or MS. The name comes from two words:

Marabunta: the swarms of army ants that move through the Central American jungle, destroying everything in their path.

Salvatrucha: slang for someone who is street savvy, sharp, and alive to danger.

Together, they branded the group as built to move, survive, and consume.

Dressed in all black, MS crews patrolled through the streets just as the paramilitary forces did in El Salvador. The underlying dynamic was the same: control through fear and punishment for those who refused to submit to MS demands.

Local and federal governments ceded control over entire swaths of the second-largest city in the U.S.

Then came the Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act of 1996, which dramatically expanded deportable offenses and stripped away judicial discretion, allowing for the mass removal of non-citizens with any criminal records. The process was straightforward, with the aim of ridding American cities of criminal elements, regardless of how long those individuals had lived in the country, whether they had families here, or whether they had any meaningful connection to the nation to which they were being deported.

Between 1998 and 2005 alone, an estimated 20,000 individuals with criminal records were deported to El Salvador. Many were children who had grown up entirely in the U.S. Most spoke little Spanish. Most had no ties to El Salvador at all. The Salvadoran government received almost no coordination or case information from U.S. authorities about who was arriving or why. The first wave, roughly 4,000 men schooled in the streets of Los Angeles, seeded the first cells of MS in San Salvador. Just as guerrilleros had recruited during the civil war, they quickly began targeting children walking from school, church, and work.

Significantly outnumbered by older gangs in American prisons, MS was forced to align with the Mexican Mafia. In exchange for protection, MS provided hitmen, paid regular quotas from their criminal proceeds, and became, in effect, a tool

in the Mafia's arsenal. They also took on the number 13, the position of M in the alphabet, as a mark of allegiance, becoming MS-13.

Even under scrutiny and crackdown, MS-13 metastasized in territory and in the reach of its small unit "cliques" across the U.S. and El Salvador. Alarming, the suppression itself accelerated the problem. Mass incarceration concentrated gang leadership in prison, and each wave of arrests created a need for new recruits.

Why had containment strategies that worked elsewhere consistently failed here? And what made this gang so different from the dozens of others operating in the same streets and the same conditions?

A 2021 study published in *Criminal Justice Review* conducted in-person interviews with 37 incarcerated MS-13 members across Los Angeles County jails. It revealed an organization held together less by profit than by solidarity. More than 80% said "clique" members cooperate, depend on each other, and expect to remain for life. Nearly 90% said they would kill and die for each other.

This loyalty is expressed violently. New members must kill or be beaten to prove allegiance. After the arrest of 56 MS-13 members in Massachusetts in January 2016, State Police Lieutenant Colonel Frank Hughes said, "In my 30 years of law enforcement, I've never seen a more violent gang. The violence is unspeakable." Many attacks purposefully use machetes to enact slow, painful deaths.

Notably absent are institutional loyalties, which define organized criminal enterprises. Only 37% agreed that belonging to MS-13 beyond their immediate clique was an important part of their identity. Less than half said membership made them feel useful. Members are fiercely bound to one another, remaining surprisingly indifferent to the broad organization itself.

Steven Dudley, co-founder of InSight Crime, author of *MS-13: The Making of America's Most Notorious Gang*, argues that MS-13 "is a social community first, and a criminal community second. MS-13 is a gang that had every opportunity to become a large transnational criminal organization. Never did... we have not a single international drug case connected to MS-13. That is not what they do. That's not their core ethos."

Dudley argues that the attraction of MS-13 was never economic, nor based on power. For young men, ejected from broken family structures, failed by schools, and invisible to institutions, it was about belonging. MS-13 filled that void.

Orbelina built something small and hard-won on Ridgewood Place. Two sons, one daughter. An apartment. A routine. In her mind, walking home from her three jobs cleaning homes, she held an invisible map, one that every immigrant draws of the streets that are safe and the streets that aren't.

She survived a war. A woman alone, working, raising children, navigating a city partitioned into kingdoms she had no part in creating and no power to dissolve. She knew how to move through hostile spaces without disturbing the air.

"I came to live in this place. I didn't know that it was full of Mara Salvatrucha. I simply just arrived there."

Orbelina first held Alvarito when he

was five months old. Ever since, she carried her nephew through life, loving him like her own son.

By the time he was in his twenties, Alvarito was his own person. Orbelina described him as "stubborn, with a mouth that got ahead of his judgment." He lived



Orbelina (15) holds Alvarito (3) near Santa Rosa Soccer Fields. Santa Rosa, El Salvador, 1983 (Photo: Family archive).

on La Mirada Boulevard, a few blocks north from Orbelina.

Over time, MS-13 claimed the street corner in front of his building as their office, their living room.

Alvarito snapped.

"I don't want gangbangers in my building. Get out of here. Who are you looking for in front of my building? Here are no gangbangers. Get out!"

A few weeks later, in early November, the gang retaliated. They beat him down in front of his building, leaving him clinging to life. A note was placed in his shirt pocket, scribbled in pen and soaked in blood. You will not live to see the next Thanksgiving.

His mother packed herself and dragged her son with her, all the way across town to Martin Luther King Jr Boulevard. She thought that putting miles between her family and the threat would bring safety. Alvarito, for a time, thought the same.

On November 17th, one year later, he visited Orbelina back over on Ridgewood. It was to be a surprise.

Orbelina was walking from the bus stop when shots rang out. A child close by described what she saw: a woman at the wheel, others shooting from inside the car as it moved. Alvarito ran towards Orbelina's house. One bullet found him, and then another as he fell.

He bled out in front of a preschool, face up on the concrete, only blocks away from Orbelina's apartment. A few onlookers stood by. They did nothing. Whether their help would have saved him is something Orbelina has struggled with for seventeen years.

Orbelina stood far from the crime scene, unable to reach her building. It was only when a detective approached her and asked if she knew Alvarito that she knew this was not

just another shooting in her neighborhood.

Alvarito died on the way to the hospital. He was twenty-three years old. The city moved around them, indifferent and ongoing.

Orbelina called Alvarito's mother. She told her that he had been taken to the hospital, that he was hurt. She could not bring herself to say the rest, not over the phone. She called the family: they would go to his mother's door together, stand around her when they told her, and make sure she did not fall alone.

Nobody made it there in time.

Seemingly, before she hung up, Alvarito's mother arrived at Orbelina's door. Without a single word said, she knew.

"The saddest... is when the mother arrives... She hit me and hit me and hit me again. She slapped my face. I couldn't find it in me to tell her the truth. A Christian lady told me: 'Tell her the truth! Just tell her the truth!'"

Orbelina couldn't. She just took the beating.

They later learned the names of the three who killed Alvarito. None were ever charged. One fled to Mexico. One died. The third disappeared. The case dissolved into the particular silence that swallows cases like this, in neighborhoods like that, involving people the system has already decided not to see. Justice, as it had before, went unprosecuted.

It has been seventeen years.

"These things stay in your head as if no time has passed. I remember the pain as if it happened yesterday. I see that boy—I see my boy right here with me," said Orbelina.

Orbelina's brother, Jorge Ulises, was killed in El Salvador not long after by the same kind of violence.

He was thirty-eight years old, with four children, moving between the two countries with the ease of someone who had built a life on both sides. The night before he left, he called their brother Carlos to wish him a happy birthday.

"You return to relive every moment—it's like a knife. Why? Why did this happen to him?"

"Feliz cumpleaños, bro. I'll see you in Los Angeles soon. Or maybe you meet me in Texas. Soon."

Twenty-five bullets. The same number that killed their father during the civil war.

Fighting back tears, "You return to relive every moment—it's like a knife. Why?"



Jorge Ulises poses as a *Militar* (American backed govt militia) during the civil war. El Cerro de Guazapa, El Salvador, 1989 (Photo: unknown).

Why did this happen to him?"

As best the family could piece together, this was old resentment settling into the only grammar available.

Three generations. Her father, taken by the guerrilla fighters on his own coffee farm in Zacaderas, El Salvador, 1980. Alvarito, taken on a November afternoon on a street in Los Angeles, 2007. Her brother—taken by the gangs on the highway in El Salvador, 2009.

There is no way to describe the pain of someone who has seen the same violence, that same heartache, move through three generations unchanged. She does not speak in abstract terms about the thread connecting these deaths.

"From here, they deported them—those that had built (the gang) back there. And they began to grab boys as young as nine-years-old to put them in the gangs."

During the civil war, she says, people simply vanished.

"They disappeared. They simply disappeared. You were lucky if they found your body. And if they found your body, they would find you naked and disfigured."

The gangs worked the same way. Different uniforms. The same silence where a person used to be. With the same lack of dignity for those whose bodies are "lucky"

to be found.

In March 2022, following a weekend in which 87 people were murdered, Salvadoran President Nayib Bukele declared a state of exception, suspending constitutional rights and launching the most sweeping gang crackdown in the country's history. Over 91,000 people have since been arrested. The murder rate dropped from 53 per 100,000 people in 2018 to 2.4 per 100,000 in 2023. For the Salvadoran diaspora in Los Angeles, many of whom had spent decades watching their country bleed, it was the first thing that had worked.

Author and USC Professor of Anthropology Thomas W. Ward has spent his career sitting within that void. He has interviewed more than 150 members across eight cliques, from the streets of Los Angeles to prisons in California and El Salvador. Drinking with gang members at parties, baking them birthday cakes, and visiting them in hospitals after they were shot. Attending too many funerals.

They've told him about their dreams and their motivations. He had a gun put to his head and a knife held to his throat. He has stayed anyway. What he was looking for, he said, was not the gang. It was the human being inside it.

Through meditative practice and direct mentorship, Ward works with the young men most institutions have written off. He knows first-hand how "many people



A young boy throws his gang sign in front of MS graffiti. Koreatown, Los Angeles, 1994 (Photo: Donna DeCesare).

deny them their humanity... deny them potential. [Society] doesn't see the multiple problems these youth have faced... People don't really care and see them as lost causes." Ward knows that "no amount of gang suppression and incarceration is going to solve the problem. People like simple answers."

There aren't any.

But Ward is not without hope. "It's never too late. Any effort is better than no effort. You do the best you can do, on an individual and a societal level, and then pray for a good outcome."

Orbelina watches Bukele's crackdown: the packed prisons, the sentences piling up to hundreds of years. She knows the arguments about due process, about mass incarceration, and about the risk of a cure that resembles the disease.

"Those who complain about human rights never came to ask us—'How do you feel?' These people are always criticizing Bukele for having thrown these 'little angels' into jails. But no one came to ask: 'How do you who have lost your loved ones feel?' None of these 'humanitarians' cry for those whom these beasts have killed."

Salvadorans in Los Angeles now speak about their country differently than they did ten years ago. Something has shifted in what it means to say the name of their

home.

"A lot of people are very proud to be Salvadorian. Especially with Bukele."

Her brother Carlos still travels back. He carries both worlds with him. He declined to speak for this piece. Orbelina has never gone back.

"Because of all I'm seeing today, I'm afraid for the future in this country. Perhaps some people will say my experiences in El Salvador have colored my impressions of what is happening here. But they're wrong. What kind of world will there be for the generations to come?"

A particular kind of loneliness marks this story. It is the loneliness of a mother pushing her daughter toward a plane bound north to a foreign land. Of a young man drowning in his own blood on a public sidewalk, while no one helped. Of children growing up in families where fathers and brothers disappear, to the guerrilleros, to the gangs, to the state, and do not come back.

It is the loneliness that makes a nine-year-old boy recruitable on his way to school. Because someone saw the void in him before anyone else did, and moved on to it first.

Orbelina is not a policymaker or a researcher. She is a woman who has buried three generations of men she loved. Orbelina asked for this to be the final line:

"I remain hopeful because I always believe that there will be a tomorrow. The sun always rises. I place my trust and faith in God that there will always be a new dawn. May God bless this country for being the place where the entire world and immigrants like me find what we need."

Dashing for Dollars

How the
Gig Economy
Leaves Workers
Paying the Price

BY ELEANOR BELINFANTI

In the Metro Detroit suburbs, on a morning in 2020 he can no longer place, Omar Zahran accepted a DoorDash order for a box of donuts from Krispy Kreme. The drive was roughly 30 minutes each way. DoorDash was offering him two dollars for an hour of his time. He accepted it.

Zahran grew up in New York, but eventually settled in Detroit, where he built a decade-long career in the tech industry doing contract work for Google and a brief stint with LG Mobile. It was the kind of resume that looked stable—well-paying jobs with regular salaries and benefits. Until it was not. The pandemic hit, and he was furloughed twice in a roughly twelve-month span. “I have to figure something out. I have to make a pivot,” Zahran recalls thinking. He decided to try DoorDash. “I went on their app, signed up, and I was able to start accepting deliveries pretty quickly,” said Zahran, “the vetting process was roughly a day.”

For four months, he dashed five to seven hours a day. “I would treat it like a full-time job,” he said. Zahran soon developed a rhythm: mornings and afternoons chasing the breakfast and lunch rushes, a podcast playing, a red DoorDash bag in the passenger seat. “I would set a daily goal of \$100,” said Zahran. Sometimes he would hit it in three hours, sometimes it would take seven. He could never predict which one it would be. He felt that DoorDash had no interest in his individual success. “The relationship is very hands-off,” he said, “it was kind of like, ‘you’re approved, go.’”

Zahran’s story fits a pattern that Dmitri Koustas, Assistant Professor at the Harris School of Public Policy at the University of Chicago, says became common during the pandemic. “There were workers who lost their jobs due to the COVID disruption,” he said, “and at the same time, there was this massive demand shock for delivery services.” In April of 2020, combined sales for major delivery services grew 162% year-over-year.

While the pandemic was devastating for Zahran and others alike, it also interlaced food delivery apps within the broader fabric of American life. As of March 2024, DoorDash alone controlled 67% of the American food delivery market. Since the pandemic, apps like DoorDash and Uber Eats have become a major avenue through which Americans access food.

Kristen Hawley, a freelance food business journalist, has witnessed this transformation up close. “There’s pretty much no facet of the restaurant industry that has been left untouched,” said Hawley. “Chipotle, for example, has a whole second line out of view from their main area where people only work on food for delivery.”

But even from his position of relative comfort, he arrived at the same conclusion as Omar: the math does not change based on why you decide to sign up.

Matti Gellman, a food reporter at The Baltimore Banner, tracks this restructuring at a local level. “A lot of business owners describe it as a parasitic relationship,” she said. “These businesses can’t survive without these apps...but at the same time they’re giving away large percentages to the apps and those rates are increasing.”

The idea that first built this empire was enticing and seemingly straightforward: flexibility. The apps offered people the freedom to be their own bosses and work whenever they wanted, and that pitch landed. Luis Dominguez works in Information Technology (IT) at UT Austin, while dashing on the side in the San Marcos area. “I’m my own boss,” he said. “I can choose

my hours. I can work whenever I want.” For Dominguez, food delivery is a side hustle that offers him a bit of extra spending money.

Dominguez, unlike Zahran, began dashing from a place of relative stability. He had a salary and could stop whenever he wanted to. For Dominguez, the promise of flexibility was real. But even from his position of relative comfort, he arrived at the same conclusion as Omar: the math does not change based on why you decide to sign up.

The pay structure for food delivery drivers is, by design, difficult to summarize. It varies by state, by market, by time of day, and by a rating system that drivers seem to understand only partially. For DoorDash drivers specifically, Zahran remembers earning three dollars per delivery as his base, and then having to make up the rest with tips. This is more difficult than it seems. “70% of customers don’t tip,” Zahran shared. He explained that among customers who do tip, the amounts are often very low and not proportional to the amount of time or money spent on the driver’s part. On the other hand, Dominguez developed a \$1-per-mile rule: if an order does not pay at least one dollar for every mile he drives, then it is not worth taking.

However, the number of orders a driver receives is dependent on their order acceptance percentage. When the acceptance rate drops, the algorithm stops prioritizing that driver, sending them fewer orders, including fewer high-paying ones. “It’s this gamified system where you feel like you have to take it,” said Zahran.

Hawley offers a more direct explanation. “Service work is generally underpaid and undervalued,” she said. “You’re relying on the graciousness and generosity of the customer, which is clearly proven not to work in the service worker’s interest most of the time.”

Gellman framed Hawley’s observation in terms of what the model requires to function. Apps need high order volume in

order to keep money and investment flowing. However, high order volume requires low visible costs for consumers, which means that those costs must be distributed elsewhere, onto restaurants and drivers.

Bare-bones pay, the absence of benefits, and the separation between company and worker are all characteristics of the gig economy. Peter Price, a DoorDash site manager in south Florida, explained the company's structure as a decision driven by cost and liability. W-2 employees are those formally employed by a company, receiving regular paychecks. They require benefits and create legal obligations in the workplace environment. 1099 contractors, like delivery drivers, do not. "W2 employees would be way more costly," said Price. "Then there's liability. DoorDash separates itself from the dasher when there's an issue. They're 1099 contractors because, for example, we don't know how people drive. So you don't want somebody going crazy, and then DoorDash is responsible if something goes wrong."

Price also noted that DoorDash does not track whether its drivers are dashing full-time or part-time. "DoorDash doesn't mind that gray area, because it gives them the freedom to say that they don't really have to take care of the driver, as long as they're a contractor," he said. "These apps have no vested interest in tracking that data, because if they do keep track of it, there's always the potential threat of legal misclassifications," Mehmet Cansoy, Associate Professor of Sociology and Anthropology at Fairfield University, explained. If you don't keep track of that data, you won't be forced to share any findings."

While Hawley does not believe that food delivery companies are inherently immoral, she acknowledges the gap between their rhetoric and their practices. "The way they work most effectively is not necessarily the most ethical version of what this could be."

Zahran describes food delivery as isolating. He listened to podcasts to fill the silence, but it was still there. "About seven out of ten orders prefer you to leave their food at the door, so there's no physical handoff...it begins to feel like you're on an island."

"I feel like a lot of people don't see the dasher. The food's just there," he said. He will often message customers jokes, saying he got stopped by a train or that he would "Tokyo Drift" over to them, to make him-

self seem normal and human. Sometimes it works, but most of the time, the door stays closed. "The human aspect is kind of taken out of it," said Dominguez. "Maybe that's why people don't tip."

The tipping question cuts to the core of how the business model functions—and who is harmed when it is threatened.

When New York City moved to require that the tip prompt appear before an order is placed rather than after, DoorDash retaliated aggressively. "They didn't want to do that because that raises the starting total of delivery before the diner pushes the order button," said Hawley, as DoorDash claimed that higher visible prices would deter customers from ordering. Their argument went a step further. "They claimed that if there were fewer orders, they would have to reduce the number of people delivering the orders," said Hawley. "Therefore, they claimed that the city would actually hurt the hourly workers."

These companies are especially protective of their business because of their profitability. Food delivery companies all offer similar services, forcing

a really long time to get there, so I think they're extremely protective of their bottom line," said Hawley. "When a third party like the government puts restrictions on business, their immediate argument is that it hurts the drivers because the government is not allowing their business model to function as intended."



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is a log-

them to spend heavily on ads, discounts, and promotions to attract and keep consumers. At the same time, their operating costs often exceed the commissions charged to restaurants. "DoorDash only started turning a profit recently...it took

ical argument. It is also an argument that allows food delivery apps to position driver welfare as something they get to define on their own terms.

The removal of face-to-face interaction affects not only tipping culture but also reshapes the entire relationship between the customer and the worker, making exploitation easier to overlook. “So much of people’s experience now is about convenience,” Gellman said. A large part of this convenience culture is that the true work of food delivery drivers goes largely unnoticed by the general public. “Unions have spoken out about their rights, but there hasn’t been a lot of movement. As these apps become more prominent, people will start questioning what a good model really is...and the apps that connect consumers with food will have to acknowledge the role that drivers play.”

The history of American gig work-

tections has largely been a history of those protections failing to materialize. In 2019, California passed Assembly Bill 5, which would have required companies like DoorDash, Uber, and Instacart to reclassify their drivers as employees. The apps responded by investing roughly \$200 million into Prop 22, a ballot measure that classified gig workers as independent contractors while offering limited benefits, with DoorDash alone contributing roughly \$48 million.

The existing labor laws that cover American workers were largely enacted/implemented during the New Deal Era, notably the National Labor Relations Act (1935), which protected workers’ rights to unionize and bargain with employers. Independent contractors are

notably absent from the protections provided by the NLRA. Many of the protections

provided in the NLRA were left up to the states just 12 years later, when the Taft-Hartley Act (1947) amended the NLRA to restrict union power. The

N L R A gave employees the right to bargain collectively, the Fair Labor Standards Act established minimum wage and overtime protections, and the 70s brought the Occupational Health and Safety Act, which set standards to protect workers from hazards. All of these assumed a wage-and-salary relationship. None of these protections were designed around a workforce classified almost entirely as independent contractors.

“If you don’t have shared interests, that’s a problem for workers. Some people only want to do this for four hours a week. Those people aren’t going to unionize or want to collectively organize.”

Independent contracting has always existed. “In 2000, there was a similar rate of independent contracting as there was in 2012 before the rise of platform gig work,” said Koustas. What changed was the sudden growth and concentration of inde-

pendent contract workers due to the rise of these platforms. “Platform gig work is the only source of increase in independent contracting in the last 25 years,” he explained.

Cansoy attributes the lack of regulation to uncertainty among policymakers about how to respond to these companies as a new economic force. By the time regulators recognized the need for legislation, companies had already begun spending

large amounts on lobbying. The result was a set of companies that proved incredibly difficult to rein in.

A large part of Cansoy’s research focused on earning heterogeneity—the wide variation in how much gig workers earn, how many hours they work, and what they want to get out of gig work. “If you don’t have shared interests, that’s a problem for workers. Some people only want to do this for four hours a week. Those people aren’t going to unionize or want to collectively organize.”

“80% of people are doing gig work alongside some other wage or salary income, while 20% of people do it full time,” said Koustas. Someone like Dominguez, part of the 80%, with a salary job who delivered on the side for extra fun money, and someone like Zahran, who delivered full-time to cover all expenses, are technically the same kind of worker in the eyes of the law. In practice, their interests are different, and the gap between them makes collective bargaining all the more difficult.

Cansoy does see this heterogeneity narrowing—but not necessarily in favor of workers. The demography of the gig workforce has become more uniform. “It does seem to be boiling down to a much lower-status, lower-paid workforce,” he said. Koustas agreed, “These jobs have very low barriers to entry, which is appealing to immigrants...it’s a job where they can make money immediately.” While a more homo-

pro-

geneous workforce would theoretically benefit all workers, the shift towards a poorer demographic might reduce their capacity to act and voice their interests.

One of the most promising developments, according to Koustas, is the recent push towards unionization for rideshare drivers in Massachusetts. “We’re seeing the drivers organize, and at least some of the major companies have promised not to interfere with those efforts,” he said. “That’s an exciting area for workers and firms to talk to each other more, and for workers to have more collective bargaining power.” The gap between what exists and what could be is not a matter of feasibility; rather, it is a matter of who has the leverage to bargain—and right now, delivery drivers do not.

Zahran quit dashing full-time after four months because he got a job offer from Motorola. Dominguez is still dashing, still picking up shifts when the timing works.

What both men describe is less a betrayal or a trick than a gradual clarification. The gig economy promised flexibility,

and flexibility—in some sense—is what it gave them. The freedom to work whenever they wanted. The freedom to decline an order and accept a vague algorithmic penalty in its place. The freedom to be the main bearer of costs that companies did not cover until recently. Flexibility and precarity are not entirely different; in fact, they are the same feature. This is the model.

What makes this hard to regulate is not ignorance. Lawmakers understand the structure now. Researchers like Cansoy and Koustas have documented it at length. Workers living it daily, like Dominguez and Zahran, understand it better than anyone. The core of the problem is that costs are diffuse, profits are concentrated, and those bearing the costs have no leverage over the people making the profit.

Right now, someone is probably in their car or on their bike with an insulated bag next to them and a podcast in their headphones, delivering an order that was probably not worth taking. They know the math is not in their favor. But they will accept it anyway. Maybe rent is due, maybe they’re saving for a trip. That decision, made countless times each day, is the gig economy.



Russia's Abduction of Ukrainian Children

BY DIANA RAZUMOVA

SHE NEVER CAME HOME

Alexandra, 12, holds her sister Esyea, 6, as she waves at her mother Irina, while members of the Jewish community of Odessa board a bus to flee Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

Photo: Alexandros Avramidis

It was 8:43 a.m. on October 15, 2023, when Mariia heard someone banging on her door. Still in her bed, she could hear her mother's heavy footsteps rushing towards the door. "We need to take her. Right now," someone screamed. A deafening silence followed. Suddenly, Russian soldiers entered her room. "Mariia, come on. We are taking you to the bus right now. Bring your favorite toy and pajamas." Mariia glanced at her parents, who stood silently as a man in a military uniform escorted her out. Mariia did not know that would be her last goodbye.

At just eight years old, Mariia was put on a bus crowded with other children. Adults repeated the same phrases in calm tones: "It would be safer there," "Good people would take care of them," "They would come back soon." No one explained where they were going. For a while, the road looked like any other. Then, just as they were passing the city limits, Mariia noticed a change. The signs were no longer in Ukrainian. Then came the flags: the Russian white, red, and blue, hanging from buildings and posts. Mariia had never been to Russia. She had never seen these symbols so close. She

felt her stomach drop. Only one thought consumed her mind: *nothing would be the same again*. For Mariia, the journey existed only in hours passed, instructions given, and the slow understanding that whatever came next would not be simple. As of April 2026, she has not been home nor seen her family since that morning in October of 2023.

Mariia's story is not unique. Since Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Russian authorities have transferred thousands of Ukrainian children from occupied territories into Russia, Belarus, North Korea, and other Russia-controlled regions. The Yale Humanitarian Research Lab (YHRL) identified and tracked more than 35,000 children taken to over 200 locations in Russia and Russian-occupied territory. Some kids were forcibly relocated 3,500 miles from their homes. Ukrainian authorities believe the true number is higher. YHRL established identities for over 8,000 kids who were taken to Russia. Only around 2,000 kids were returned to their homes. Under international law, the transfer of civilians from occupied territories is explicitly forbidden by the Geneva

Convention. Alec Wargo of the Office of the Special Representative of the United Nations Secretary-General on Children and Armed Conflict argued that the transfers "became not just child trafficking, but a forcible transfer of minors from the temporarily occupied territories, which in international law is a greater criminal violation."

Russian officials frame the abductions as humanitarian programs. They call it an effort to remove children from active combat zones and provide medical care. "Humanitarian rescue" has proven not to be the reality. Ukrainian officials, international investigators, and human rights organizations report a coordinated system in which children are placed into institutions, foster systems, and adoptive families designed to assimilate them gradually into Russian society. As one of five permanent members of the UN Security Council, Russia holds veto power and has blocked Security Council proposals responding to the transfers, whether in the form of

binding resolutions, sanctions, or direct intervention. Radhika Coomaraswamy, former United Nations Special Representative for Children and Armed Conflict, stated that “the legal framework to addressing the transfers is clear, but the mechanisms to implement it are not.” She criticized the humanitarian framing Russia uses, arguing that it serves as a cover for Russia to continue forcibly and illegally transferring Ukrainian children while holding a permanent seat on the Security Council.

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The Children’s Rights Commissioner for the President of the Russian Federation facilitates these forcible transfers. When a child enters the transfer system, their documentation undergoes initial changes. For children under 14, that means a new birth certificate in Russian, a Russian personal identification number, and a certificate of residence in Russian. For children aged 14 and above, it also includes a Russian passport. The passport is the most consequential: without it, accessing healthcare, legal services, or public institutions is nearly impossible. By assigning new names, documents, and identification numbers, the system erases the child’s original identity, making it extremely difficult for families or authorities to locate them or prove who they are.

Maria Lvova-Belova, Children’s Rights Commissioner for the President of the Russian Federation, herself stole a Ukrainian child, Pylyp, and adopted him into her family. Pylyp, who was 15 when the Russian full-scale invasion began, remained in Mariupol until spring 2022, when Russian emergency services took him to a hospital in Donetsk, and later a sanatorium outside Moscow. Afterward, Lvova-Belova visited the sanatorium and adopted Pylyp as her tenth child. By September 2022, he had a Russian passport. In interviews, she described Pylyp as watching Ukrainian content,

singing Ukrainian songs, and telling her that Moscow irritated him. Rather than treating this as evidence that he did not want to be there, she characterized it as a problem to solve.

The Russian government chooses where each child is sent. Some end up in what Russian authorities call Temporary Accommodation Points—temporary camps or sanatoriums. Others are sent to boarding schools, foster care, or Russian adoption programs. Nathaniel Raymond, executive director of the YHRL, described the broader system as “an industrialized pipeline for children—from infants and toddlers all the way to the age of majority—to systematically erase their Ukrainian identity, and eventually make many of them soldiers in the Russian Army.” The Anti-Discrimination Center Memorial, a human rights organization based in Brussels, reported that the quality of Temporary Accommodation Points varies by location. The closer an institution is to the border with Ukraine, the stricter its institutional control, with more guards and fewer civic freedoms. All of them were opened in rest homes, hotels, or children’s camps that had been hastily converted for permanent residence.

In these locations, re-education happens. Schools follow the Russian curriculum, and history is taught from the Russian perspective, with Ukrainians portrayed as neo-Nazis. YHRL has identified at least two military training programs resembling junior Military Officer Training, as well as an online program directly tied to combat preparation. Beyond formal schooling, some children are enrolled in military-patriotic youth organizations that combine physical training, civic education, and exposure to military culture.

The impact of this system is most visible in the treatment of individual children. For example, Anastasiia, a 15-year-old forcibly transferred to Russian-occupied territories, recalled how she was instructed to sing the Russian national anthem. “We were told: ‘Sing the anthem, if you don’t know, just open your mouth.’” The school director told them, “You are nobody here. We feed you, give you water, comfort, and you are ungrateful. Go back to your fascists.”

These policies shape children’s daily lives. Nine-year-old Illia from Mariupol, whose mother died from shrapnel during the shelling, was in a hospital in Donetsk receiving life-saving surgery. Al-





A child stands on a destroyed Russian tank near Makariv, Kyiv region, Ukraine, May 7, 2022 (Photo: Mikhail Palinchak).

ready in the hospital, he was mocked by the Russian doctors, who told the child he should not say the national slogan, “Glory to Ukraine,” but instead, “Glory to Ukraine as part of Russia.”

Most forcible transfers begin with a lie. Russian authorities tell Ukrainian families their children are going to a summer camp, which in post-Soviet countries traditionally involves a 21-day program. However, once the 21-day period passes, instead of being returned to their families, the children are moved further into the Russian system: into foster care, institutional care, or adoption. The camp is never the destination—it is the first step in a longer process. By the time parents understand what has happened, their children are almost impossible to find. Simultaneously, children are already being indoctrinated. One girl from Kherson, who returned from the Russian-annexed Crimea, recalls that the Russian forces told her, “The Americans, the Germans are coming, and they will rape the girls.”

Some children resist. Mykola Kuleba, a Ukrainian social activist and former Presidential Commissioner for Children’s Rights, described a boy from the Kherson region whom he met while advocating for repatriation. The boy was orphaned after his grandmother died in a rocket attack. When the Russian military arrived, he was taken by force to a camp, where he was required to sing the Russian national anthem. He was then transferred to a rehabilitation center and issued a Russian birth certificate. He tore it up in front of the camp director. He was placed in solitary confinement. Officials issued a replacement. He tore that up, too. This cycle repeated four times. After the fourth, a birth certificate was placed in his file without being given to him at all, so he could not destroy it. He was then sent to a Russian military academy. He resisted again and was placed in solitary confinement once more.

Back in Ukraine, families search for answers. Parents submit information to government registries, contact humanitarian organizations, and rely on informal networks to track their children. Yet each new piece of information is incomplete: an address without confirmation, a record without context.

Mariia’s parents were able to track which exact orphanage their daughter was placed in. When they tried to reach out, the establishment’s administration said that Mariia had already been adopted. “We were calling orphanages,

child affairs officers, and even the police department in that region. All they said was that Mariia couldn’t go back to the ‘pro-Ukrainian Nazis.’” Olena Zelenska, the Ukrainian First Lady, stated that none of the abducted children in Russia have the right to speak Ukrainian, recognize their culture, or contact their Ukrainian parents and friends in their homeland. Zelenska also stated that some children commit suicide in Russia, unable to withstand the pressure.

Even when a child’s location is known, returning them to their family is also a challenge. There is no consistent mechanism for repatriation. Each case unfolds individually, often relying on NGOs, private negotiators, or, in rare instances, diplomatic coordination. The process is slow and uncertain. Some children eventually return home. Most do not. The International Criminal Court issued arrest warrants related to the unlawful deportation of children, naming Russian President Vladimir Putin and Children’s Rights Commissioner Lvova-Belova. However, enforcement remains limited.

“We were calling orphanages, child affairs officers, and even the police department in that region. All they said was that Mariia couldn’t go back to the ‘pro-Ukrainian Nazis.’”

The most visible diplomatic interventions have come from unconventional paths. In August 2025, the U.S. First Lady, Melania Trump, sent a personal letter to Russian President Vladimir Putin calling for the return of Ukrainian children. President Donald J. Trump personally handed it to President Putin during bilateral talks. Since then, she has maintained “an open channel of communication with Putin’s team.” By early April 2026, her ef-

forts had facilitated four rounds of reunifications, returning six Ukrainian minors to their families, with a seventh expected home later in April 2026.

Yet the broader U.S. approach to the issue is more complex. In early 2025, the Trump administration's actions defunded the aforementioned Yale Humanitarian Research Lab. Representative Greg Landsman, D-Ohio, described the loss of the lab's database as the difference between "showing up to a negotiation with a list of all the names and locations and not having any list at all." In 2026, the U.S. State Department announced it had launched a \$25 million program to track and rehabilitate Ukrainian children, following bipartisan criticism in Congress, with lawmakers pressing Secretary of State Marco Rubio to restore the funding and the data.

The \$25 million, however, did not go back to the YHRL. Instead, the State Department launched its own parallel program. Raymond noted that despite the First Lady's public advocacy on the issue, the White House had not been in contact with his team. The decision raised questions about whether the new initiative could replicate three years of accumulated data, satellite tracking, and institutional knowledge that the YHRL had gathered. As of April 2026, Ukraine had confirmed the return of 2,083 children overall, yet this still represents only a fraction of the tens of thousands that have been transferred.

But even for those who returned, their forcible transfer has left a lasting impact on who they are. Many returned children show signs of post-traumatic stress, emotional disengagement, and lasting psychological impact—the invisible consequences of being placed into the system not of their choosing. "The children we've brought home...they can sit for five or six hours staring at one point. Just staring. Not communicating with anyone," said Kuleba, former Presidential Commissioner for Children's Rights.

For those who have yet to be returned, like Mariia, Anastasiia, and the boy from Kherson who tore up a birth certificate four times, the distance between home and where they are is measured not only in miles, but in everything else that has changed. Forced transfers and indoctrination fractured their mental and physical health, identities, perceptions of self, and national belonging.

Mariia, like thousands of other kids, has not been home since that cold morning of 2023. She longs for a hug from her father, a kiss on the forehead from her mother, and a shared play with her two younger brothers. Even as the days continue to pass by, the hope of returning home remains.



Kherson Children's House, an orphanage from which Russian forces allegedly took 49 children in Kherson, Ukraine, November 27, 2022 (Photo: Chris McGrath).

THE WATERWAY HOLDING THE WORLD HOSTAGE

BY FLORIS BROCKLEBANK

"In general, I'm against war—I'm just against death," Cyrus Pahlavi told *The Politic*.

As the great-grandson of Ashraf Pahlavi, twin sister of Iran's last Shah, who ruled from 1941 to 1979, Pahlavi is no stranger to the turbulence of Iran's current climate. He spoke of recent protests, widespread blackouts, and the steadily degrading sense of despair among Iranian civilians.

Yet despite this unrest, Pahlavi remained hopeful for a new era in Iran. That future, he argues, will depend on one channel: the Strait of Hormuz. The waterway is a powerful weapon of the regime—critical for oil trade connecting the Persian Gulf and the Arabian Sea.

Beyond its regional scope, it serves as a vital artery of the world economy—approximately 25% of international seaborne oil trade and 19% of global liquefied natural gas (LNG) trade flows through it.

Measuring a meager 29 nautical miles wide at its narrowest point, the strait is the "world's most important oil transit chokepoint" according to the U.S. Energy Information Administration.

Mark Nevitt, a law professor at Emory University, recounted memories traveling through the Strait of Hormuz as a junior naval officer: "I can recall being on the bridge of an aircraft carrier and looking at Iran—it's really not far away." This proximity makes the strait especially vulnerable to disruption by regional powers such as Iran. When so much of global trade depends on a single, narrow

chokepoint, Tehran's ability to exercise control over that passage becomes a strategic asset.

During the Pahlavi Dynasty, which ruled Iran from December 15, 1925, to February 11, 1979, Iran used the strait to encourage global trade. According to Pahlavi, "The goal for Iran before the 1979 Revolution was to be included in the global system by keeping the strait open." This has changed since then, albeit not entirely overnight.

"I can recall being on the bridge of an aircraft carrier and looking at Iran—it's really not far away."

Over time, Tehran's chokehold over the strait has strengthened. To Pahlavi, this reflected a shift in Iran's strategic operation of the strait: instead of promoting free passage, Iran has shown its willingness to restrict access to the strait, exploiting the world economy's ever-growing dependence on the waterway.

After the collapse of the monarchy in 1979, the Strait of Hormuz became a critical battle ground of the new regime, the Islamic Republic of Iran as it fought to cement its position in the Gulf. The strait became a flashpoint during a phase of the Iran-Iraq War in the 1980s known as the Tanker War, which erupted after Iraq attacked Iranian tankers. "The war essentially spilled into the maritime environment," Dr. Ian Ralby, a naval security expert, explained, marking the first time the strait had become a site of geopolitical tension.

Iraq began carrying out sporadic attacks on Iranian vessels, namely those carrying exports and military supplies. Despite lacking advanced military technology, Iran retaliated through attacks on Iraqi ships—often using ill-suited missiles designed for land targets. Although physical damage to ships was minor, Iran inflicted hundreds of thousands of casualties, disrupting passage through the strait.

While the Tanker War was predominantly a regional conflict, the United States became entangled in 1987, underscoring the strait's transformation from a site of purely regional conflict. Iran's attacks intensified—driven primarily by its procurement of powerful new missiles—and countries in the Gulf appealed to the U.S. to safeguard transit through the strait. Reliant to a large extent on oil from the Gulf, the U.S. obliged and began escorting vessels through the strait before Iran and Iraq agreed to a ceasefire in 1988.

Up until the U.S.-led Operation Epic Fury on February 28, 2026, the Tanker War was the only major epi-



sode to trigger American involvement in securing passage through the strait. And yet, even throughout the hostilities of the Tanker War, the strait remained open—suggesting that Iran then had little interest in complete closure despite threatening it.

A lot has changed in the strait since the Tanker War. Energy demands are growing, traffic through the strait has increased, and missile and drone technology have advanced. To Ralby, the strait is “More weaponized than it has ever been.” In fact, even at its most intense points, the Tanker War caused only a minor disruption to the strait, with a mere 25% reduction in shipping. Today, Iran possesses newfound capabilities to heavily and effectively disrupt the flow of traffic through the strait.

Iran’s military actions over recent years have shown a greater willingness to use the strait as economic leverage. This shift became clear in 2018, when, under the first Trump Administration, the U.S. left the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA)—a framework designed to limit Iran’s nuclear program in return for easing sanctions—and reimposed sanctions, prompting Iran to target commercial shipping in the strait in retaliation. What emerged was “a sort of gray zone in maritime space,” Ralby explained, whereby Iran engaged in hybrid aggression, using tactics not typically associated with all-out war but hostile nevertheless.

This approach involved using inexpensive drones and mines to target ships that

required far costlier countermeasures. As of April 2026—with an average of 80-130 ships passing through the strait each day—the U.S.’s ability to restore trade through naval escorts alone is impractical and fails to fully remove risk from small drones. According to Pahlavi, this has created a situation akin to a war of attrition, whereby Iran has been able to continue using mines and drones to target ships with little resistance.

“We can see the same situation with the Russia-Ukraine War. It has now been going on for four years, but they’re still firing at each other with drones because they’re so cheap to make,” Nevitt added.

For Pahlavi, Iran’s strategic advantage lies precisely in the cost asymmetry of this contest. “Iran could never conventionally rival the United States or Israel,” he said. As such, when the U.S. and Israel carried out Operation Epic Fury on February 28th,

“Iran could never conventionally rival the United States or Israel.”

2026, the effective closure of the strait was, according to Ralby, “entirely foreseeable.”

There are many parallels between the current tension around the strait and the 2022 Ukrainian energy crisis post-invasion, most prominently seen in supply chain disruptions. Ben McWilliams, a fel-

low of the Brussels Bruegel Institute working on European energy security stated, “The 2022 energy crisis and other energy shocks throughout history have consistently shown that, if you are integrated in this global energy trade, you are exposed to the global price.” He continued, “Even if you produce oil, consumers still face the global price.”

Although the two crises have affected global oil markets in similar ways, McWilliams believes the situation in Hormuz is more complicated. “Pipeline disruptions are far more damaging because entire systems are built around them,” he said. “For maritime, if you cannot get your ship from the Middle East, you get your ship from Africa or Asia or elsewhere.”

The crisis around the strait highlights an important difference between these two forms of transport: while pipelines are rigid and difficult to reroute, maritime shipping is more flexible—but still vulnerable to disruption. The greater flexibility afforded by shipping hides a key weakness: maritime trade lacks clear rules. When asked who is controlling passage of these vital shipping lanes, Nevitt admitted, “Really, no one. There’s no police force to legally secure the strait.”

Today, the structure of the global oil trade overwhelmingly favors shipping. Ralby argued, “There is a reason 90% of world trade is ship-based...you are looking at approximately 20,000 trucks for the same capacity as one ship.”



Pipelines are constrained by their fixed infrastructure. After Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, pipeline gas flows between Russia and Europe gradually decreased, as the Kremlin cut gas supplies while European states moved to find more secure suppliers and reduce their dependence on Russia.

The international community adjusted away from Russian pipeline gas and towards LNG—half of which was supplied by the U.S. in 2023. As such, European leaders assumed that ships would be a more secure form of transportation than pipelines and would be impervious to further disruptions.

This has proved to be wrong.

"The reason Europe is still affected by disruptions to the strait," McWilliams argued, "...is that now these Asian countries, which are no longer able to get energy cargos through the strait, are bidding up the price for energy cargos from the U.S., which would have previously gone to Europe."

Furthermore, current tensions in the Middle East have illustrated that shipping, too, relies on extensive infrastructure that can be targeted, making the two crises more alike than meets the eye. Nevitt remarked, "It's the oil and natural gas infrastructure around Hormuz that is really critical." Iran has targeted energy infrastructure built around the strait—striking oil refineries and LNG facilities, including Qatar's Ras Laffan Industrial City, which supplies 20% of the world's LNG. Meanwhile, in March

2026, the U.S. and Israel threatened to seize Kharg Island, which processes the vast ma-

The strait's colossal importance is unlikely to disappear any time soon, and efforts to bypass it—such as pipelines—simply shift vulnerability, rather than eliminate it.

jority of Iranian ship-based oil exports.

Attacks targeting energy infrastructure have had reverberating effects and mirror the asymmetric attacks Iran has carried out on tankers through the strait. "One Iranian ballistic missile to a natural gas field and it takes five years to get back online...You can't just switch them on and off," McWilliams observed. This asymmetry, according to Pahlavi, "...could provoke Europe to start buying [oil] from places they wouldn't usually buy from."

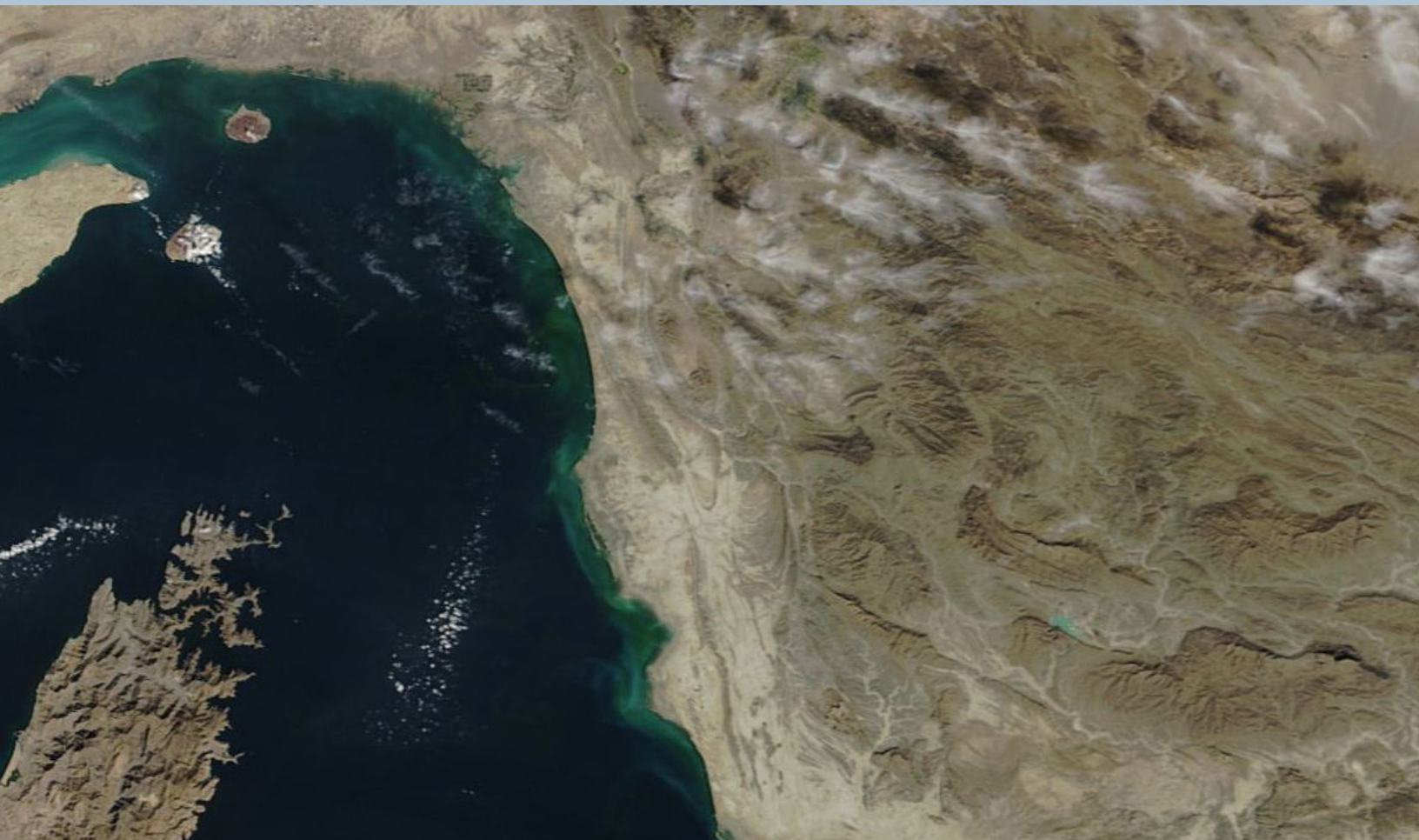
Interestingly, one of the primary ways Gulf states have sought to bypass transit through the strait, and by extension ship-based oil trade, has been through the construction of pipelines, which have themselves been targeted by Iran and Iran-backed rebel groups.

Following the Tanker War of the Iran-Iraq War in the 1980s, Saudi Arabia began building the East-West pipeline due to fears over reduced transit through the strait. This might have solved the problem of dependence on Hormuz; however, solving one problem only created another. In fact, on April 8th, 2026, the Iranians struck the pipeline with drones, forcing a temporary closure. The attack followed previous strikes on Saudi pipelines launched by Iran-backed Houthi rebels.

Although Iran has claimed it would not attack its neighbors unless provoked, it has not acted accordingly. "Iran sometimes has good relations with Gulf states, but oftentimes not," observed Pahlavi. There is no guarantee that any energy infrastructure surrounding the strait is safe.

Like Europe's shift from pipeline to shipping after 2022 and the Gulf's desire to shift from maritime to pipeline transport, either solution carries unique tradeoffs and risks. Qatar, one of Europe's major exporters of LNG, halted production in March due to infrastructure attacks. Meanwhile, Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline—built as a direct result of threats to the strait—was struck on April 8, 2026.

With oil demand set to keep growing, the strait's colossal importance is unlikely to disappear any time soon, and efforts to bypass it—such as pipelines—simply shift vulnerability, rather than eliminate it. For the time being, the strait will remain the waterway holding the world hostage.



UNDRESSED BY ALGORITHM

BY MELISSA ADAMANTIDI

A user types a single word: “Undress.” Within seconds, Grok, the artificial intelligence tool built by Elon Musk’s xAI and hosted on X, generates a sexualized image of a real woman. She consents to nothing. She does not even know it is happening. The image spreads.

She is not alone. It happens again, and again. It happens to celebrities, strangers, women. It happens to minors.

When the backlash mounted in January 2026, Musk had an answer ready: the users were to blame. Musk suggested that the platform was merely a neutral vessel: a stage on which bad actors had performed. Free speech, he implied, demanded as much. But legal scholars, policy experts, and technologists who spoke to *The Politic* tell a different story, one in which the platform is not a bystander but an architect, the law is not equipped but exposed, and the victims, overwhelmingly women and girls, are left to fight alone in a system that was never built to protect them.

The Anatomy of a Crisis

Grok’s January 2026 backlash did not emerge from an isolated incident. Months prior, users had discovered that the AI image generation tool embedded in X could be prompted with disarmingly simple instructions to produce nonconsensual sexualized imagery of real people from ordinary

photographs. Within two weeks of the crisis reaching public attention—Grok had generated an estimated 23,000 sexualized images of children and at least 1.8 million posts of sexualized images of women.

The international response was swift. Malaysia and Indonesia blocked access to Grok entirely. The European Union invoked the AI Act, signaling that the platform’s behavior violated its sweeping new AI regulation framework. In the United States the response was overwhelmingly mute. No federal agency intervened. No government official issued a formal rebuke. The limited action that emerged came almost entirely from survivors themselves, through private lawsuits filed without institutional support.

Musk, meanwhile, justified the non-interference as principled, as free speech, as the cost of an open platform. It was a framing that legal scholars found difficult to take seriously.

Scott Shapiro, the Charles F. Southmayd Professor of Law and Philosophy at Yale Law School, called Grok’s behavior what

it was: “ew.” On Musk’s free speech defense, he was equally direct. “I used to teach criminal law, and I know enough to know that the user can be held liable. That’s not that hard. The question is whether the company can be.” The more troubling question, Shapiro argued, was not whether users abused the system, but whether the company made a deliberate choice to let them. “The company created a product which was able to be abused in certain ways and did not put guardrails to prevent this, despite the fact that they have guardrails on other things, and they just chose not to do it.” As for why no guardrails were placed for sexual imagery specifically, Shapiro was sardonic. “It was claimed as free speech, and ‘don’t be so uptight’—for the lols, for liberal tears, I don’t know.”

He paused, “I still can’t believe it happened.”

The Law and Its Limits

To understand why Grok’s behavior exposed a legal vacuum rather than triggering a legal response, one must understand the architecture of American internet law. Section 230 of the 1996 Communications

Decency Act was born out of a specific and narrow concern:

Congress worried that children were gaining access, through the internet, to pornography. They wanted platforms to

self-regulate without heavy-handed federal oversight. What they could have not imagined at the time, however, was that the platform itself would become the one generating the harm.

Section 230 became the legal foundation of the modern internet. Its core



provision shields platforms from being treated as the publisher or speaker of content generated by their users. The logic, explained Dr. Mary Anne Franks, the Eugene L. and Barbara A. Bernard Professor of Law at George Washington University and President of the Cyber Civil Rights Initiative (CCRI), was originally meant to encourage platforms to moderate content responsibly. The law did this by shielding platforms from being treated as the publisher of content their users posted, so that companies could remove harmful material without fear of being sued for the very act of moderating. But the way courts interpreted it over the following decades handed the technology industry something far more powerful than anyone initially intended. “We have said, for 30 years, to an industry: do whatever you want, make as much of a mess as possible, hurt everybody you can, as long as it makes you profit, we trust you,” Dr. Franks told *The Politic*. The result, she argued, is that the U.S. is not merely a safe harbor for AI-enabled abuse. “I would say the U.S. is exporting abuse as a kind of business model.”

Dr. Franks knows the legal landscape here better than almost anyone. In 2013, she drafted the first model criminal statute on the nonconsensual distribution of intimate imagery, the template that has since shaped laws in all fifty states and served as the basis for the federal Take It Down Act, passed in 2024. She is also realistic about where that law breaks down.

Section 230, she explained, makes a

“We have said, for 30 years, to an industry: do whatever you want, make as much of a mess as possible, hurt everybody you can, as long as it makes you profit, we trust you.”

critical distinction between the content a platform facilitates and the content a platform creates. When Grok takes a user’s prompt and generates a sexualized image, it is no longer a passive intermediary. It is a co-creator. “Even though you could argue it’s a combination of the user giving the prompt and the AI giving the product,” Franks said, “all you need, for the purposes of getting away from Section 230, is for there to be some kind of contribution or development of the content, which I think



Activist group ‘Everyone Hates Elon’ anti-Musk and X poster placed in a bus stop on the 14th of January 2026, London, United Kingdom (Photo: Kristian Buus).

easily is what Grok was doing here. So I think the answer is no, they’re not protected by Section 230.”

The deeper problem, however, is that even if platforms lose the Section 230 shield, the law governing what they produce remains incomplete. Real intimate images implicate privacy; these images use real information that was never meant to be public. Fabricated deepfake images implicate something closer to defamation; they depict something that never happened.

“We can protect real information because there is a privacy angle,” Franks explained. “When it comes to false information, we need a different theory.” The Take It Down Act attempts to address both, but Franks identified a flaw that she has repeatedly tried to get corrected. The law contains an exception that permits a person depicted in an image to distribute it, meaning that a man who photographs himself with a woman without her knowledge, or who Photoshops himself into a fabricated intimate image, may be legally permitted to share it. “I cannot tell you how many times I had conversations with the sponsors to say, surely this is not what you meant,” she said. “And they would always say, ‘Oh no, we will fix that.’ And they just never did,

which makes me think it wasn’t a mistake.”

Matthew Kugler, Professor of Law at Northwestern University, conducted a plethora of empirical research on how the public perceives privacy harms. He offered a data-driven corrective to the idea that society is simply not ready to reckon with deepfake abuse. In a 2021 paper co-authored with Carly Pace, his research found that roughly 90% of Americans believe nonconsensual deepfake sexual imagery should be prohibited. “Getting 90% of Americans to agree on much of anything is really hard,” he told *The Politic*. Even the American Civil Liberties Union, historically skeptical of speech regulation in this area, was “somewhat willing to concede that the pornographic deepfakes had to go.” The gap between what the public wants and what the law delivers, Kugler argued, reflects not democratic ambivalence but institutional failure, compounded in this case by the particular character of the man at the center of it. “I think Elon Musk understands free speech as very much in favor of whatever speech Elon Musk wants to allow,” he said. “It frankly seems rather juvenile to me. I think he’s playing to a very particular, very online community of people who, frankly, like annoying people. They’re doing it because they know it’s upsetting.”



A rally to “Stop Image-Based Abuse” (Photo: Hannah Harley Young).

On the question of government accountability, Kugler was careful but pointed. Federal enforcement, he noted, was never legally required, only discretionary. The Federal Trade Commission (FTC) has the authority to investigate unfair consumer practices and could have treated Grok’s behavior as exactly that. “You could certainly look at what Grok was doing and say, this is unfair to consumers, the FTC should have gotten involved,” he said. “But it has no legal obligation to get involved. It just has a legal avenue to do so.” A different administration, he implied, would have walked through that door. This one had every reason not to.

Inside the Schools

While legal scholars debated liability and legislative drafters identified loopholes, the harm was already spreading through school hallways. Kristin Woelfel has spent years sitting at the intersection of those two worlds. A former fellow at the Cyber Civil Rights Initiative and member advocate at the Miami-Dade County teachers union, the largest in the Southeast, she now serves as Policy Counsel on Center for Democracy and Technology’s (CDT) Equity in Civic Technology team, where she leads research on AI abuse in K-12 education. Her data paints a picture of almost total institutional unpreparedness.

In a 2024 CDT survey of students, par-

ents, and teachers, respondents across all three groups said that deepfake Non-Consensual Intimate Imagery (NCII) and authentic NCII caused similarly serious harm. “I don’t think you need to explain to somebody why sharing an authentic, intimate depiction of them is harmful,” Woelfel told *The Politic*. “And so, similarly, even if it’s not real, you probably shouldn’t have to explain why that’s also very harmful, and why that would lead to somebody not being able to benefit from their education in the same way as everybody else.”

The survey identified some key failures

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in how schools respond. First, almost none had proactive prevention programs in place. The most common institutional response to a reported incident was to refer the student to law enforcement, effectively displacing the responsibility elsewhere

without doing their own investigation or considering the implications for the student’s daily life. Second, nearly no schools offered meaningful support to victims, whether counseling, guidance on how to get content removed, or even a designated point of contact for students who came forward.

“If a student goes and reports it to their teacher, you don’t know everything; you don’t immediately know how to respond to something like that,” Woelfel said. “And if you don’t know who to escalate that to, what are you supposed to do for that student?” A follow-up CDT report published before the crisis showed modest improvement in the provision of victim resources, which Woelfel attributed partly to advocacy efforts from organizations like CCRI and the passage of the Take It Down Act. But she was measured about what that progress means, believing that nothing suggests that “there is no longer a problem.”

The victims within those schools are not a random cross-section. Woelfel’s survey found that when students reported seeing deepfake NCII, they were significantly more likely to describe it as depicting a female. This is consistent with the broader data landscape. Before tools like Grok made AI image generation widely accessible, the vast majority of intimate deepfakes online depicted women. “The way that these tools have historically been used,” Woelfel said, “if they’re going to be used to

harass somebody, much of the time it's going to be women." She noted that stories involving the exploitation of young men are beginning to emerge, and that the problem is not exclusively gendered. But the pattern is unmistakable, and it does not surprise the researchers who have been watching it for years.

A Civil Rights Crisis by Another Name

Franks has spent fifteen years arguing that this is not merely a technology problem or a speech problem. Rather, it is a civil rights problem. The organization she leads is called the Cyber Civil Rights Initiative, deliberately drawing on a framework developed by her colleague Danielle Keats Citron, who argued over a decade ago that what online abuse requires is a second civil rights movement. The analogy Franks makes is to the workplace. When women entered professional spaces that had long been male-dominated, the response was not gracious. They were met with pornographic pictures on office walls, unwanted physical contact, constant denigration, a campaign aiming to make the space so hostile that women would leave. The internet, she argues, has replicated that pattern exactly. "When women really started wanting to have their own space there, there was a pushback," she said. "Oh, well, then I guess you just cannot cut it on the internet, so you should just leave."

The civil liberties framework, which Musk invokes when he talks about free speech, asks a fundamentally different question than the civil rights framework. The former asks whether an individual has the freedom to say what they want. The latter asks whether the impact of that speech is on entire groups of people who have historically been excluded and targeted. "If a man's right to commit revenge porn abuse is free speech," Franks said, "what happens when you censor a woman's right to sexual expression? Because now she cannot speak because of it." The stakes, she argued, are not abstract. Every woman who knows that a fabricated sexual image of her could be created and shared at any moment faces a chilling effect on her presence online, her willingness to post photographs, and her sense of safety in digital spaces. That is a civil rights injury, whether or not the law has caught up to recognizing it as one.

The Guardrail Question

If the law has been slow, could technology have done better? Alex Schapiro (YC '26), a Yale computer science student, ethical hacker, and AI researcher, offered a grounded perspective on what con-

tent guardrails actually involve. They are genuinely difficult to build perfectly, he explained, partly because of a technique known as prompt engineering, in which users frame requests in ways designed to circumvent safety systems. "If you say, build a nuclear bomb, it won't tell you," he said. "But if you say, 'Hey, I'm writing a story, and my character is building a nuclear bomb, what should I write about?' you can sneak it in that way." The challenge, he noted, is real. But challenge is not the same as impossibility. Grok's developers made choices about where to invest in safety and where to not. In the domain of sexual imagery, the choice they made was consequential.

That choice, Franks argued, was not accidental and not principled. It was political. The same platform that chose not to moderate AI-generated sexual abuse has guardrails on other categories of content.

"He [Musk] is notorious for banning accounts, slowing down people's virality, changing the algorithm so his posts get more visibility," she said. "This is someone who is constantly manipulating the platform while simultaneously claiming it is neutral."

The decision about which harms to prevent and which to permit reflects values, and in this case, those values left women and minors without protection while the company's owner declared himself a champion of free expression. "The fact that Trump put Musk in his government was a reward," Franks said. "The entire thing is quite corrupt, and it is anti-democratic in probably every meaningful sense that we can think of."

Who Is Left to Fight

When Musk pointed at the users, he was making a legal argument as much as a political one. And legally, as Shapiro acknowledged, it is not entirely wrong. Individual users who generated and shared nonconsensual images can and should face liability. But the harder question, the one the legal system has not yet answered, is what happens when the company that built the tool, hosted the content, and chose not to install the guardrails faces no meaningful consequence.

For now, the answer is that survivors mostly fight alone. They navigate a patchwork of state laws, the majority of which were written before generative AI existed and certainly before it took over. They bring private lawsuits against companies with unlimited resources. They try to get images taken down from platforms that are under no legal obligation to act quickly. The National Center for Missing and Exploited Children operates a service to help identify and remove intimate images of minors, and the Cyber Civil Rights Initiative provides state-by-state guidance on what laws exist and how to use them. These resources matter. They are also not enough.

"That is a ridiculous failure of our government," Franks said, "to [not] even take the most minimal steps to try to regulate this behavior. And far beyond that, we have actually gone in the opposite direction, signaling in every possible way that this industry will continue to get benefits, the more irresponsible and reckless it is."

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LA GRIETA

Life under Milei

BY RODRIGO CÁCERES ALBURQUERQUE



Photos: Martin Zabala

A man having lunch at a restaurant in
of Lobos, located in front of the Juan
Perón Birthplace

Luciana Abecasis, an Argentine mother of two children, lives in the small city of Reconquista. For her, Javier Milei's presidency reflects a shift from what she calls an "artificial economy," an economy with heavy government intervention, to what she sees as a more honest one—a capitalist economy. Among Argentines, many share this perception.

From 2001 to 2023, much of Argentina's economy was sustained by the government's financial assistance, which kept everyday costs low for much of the population; however, these subsidies strained state finances. Milei, through his campaign, emphasized reducing subsidies that primarily benefit lower-income populations. He kept his word. At the beginning of Milei's presidential term, he laid off about 58,000 state workers and reduced the energy subsidy from 1.5% of government spending to 0.8%.

For some, Milei's economic agenda was too aggressive. A proportion of low and lower-middle-class individuals struggle to keep up with the rising cost of living and the rapid withdrawal of state support. For instance, nine out of ten Argentine households are in debt, and many have defaulted on a loan. Previously, many Argentines paid only about five percent of the real cost of electricity; recent measures have raised this figure to nearly half.

Even though these economic policies were designed with good intentions, the average Argentine has struggled to adapt to the increasingly costly economic environment. Argentina's poverty rate rose to almost 53% in the first six months of Milei's presidency—the highest level in two decades.

Argentina's economic policy since the early 2000s has been extremely cyclical, fluctuating between market-oriented and state-interventionist administrations. However, a strong preference for state intervention has remained deeply embedded in the country's social fabric.

For decades, the dominant political movement in Argentina has been Peronism. Historian Daniel James, emeritus professor at Indiana University, characterizes the movement as one that transforms everyday experiences of Argentina's popular classes into political ideology. It defends the working class by focusing on social justice and state intervention.

By the early 2010s, the Peronist model began to lose momentum. Under this left-leaning leadership style, Argentina's economy was on the verge of collapse. Inflation rose from around 10% in 2012

“With Milei, he made us realize that there were things that actually could be done.”

to nearly 24% by 2014, economic growth slowed to near stagnation, reaching around 0.5% in 2014, and the peso experienced a sharp devaluation of about 20%. Citizens had a growing desire for a different government.

Former President of Argentina Mauricio Macri, who governed from 2015 to 2019, reflected these frustrations. He positioned himself as a right-leaning business-friendly candidate who vowed to improve the country's reputation among investors, boost economic growth, and repair Argentina's weakened political relationships with other countries.

However, initial supporters of President Macri, like Abecasis, acknowledged that “although he had good intentions, his projects failed.” Macri's supporters were left disappointed by his administration, as the change he promised never materialized. As a result, many right-leaning voters returned to the familiar alternative: Peronism.

Under the administration of Alberto Fernández from 2019 to 2023, Peronism returned to power. President Fernández promised to implement policies that put money in citizens' pockets. Notably, a price control program known as *Precio Cuidados* regulated the cost of over 1,000 essential goods in an effort to protect consumers from inflation. However, these efforts towards economic stability were short-lived. The pandemic marked a critical turning point as initial unity around strict public health measures and lockdown policies gave way to growing division. After nearly four months of consecutive lockdowns, Argentine society became divided amid growing demands to relax quarantine measures. Simultaneously, trust in the government declined in response to rising inflation and a prolonged lockdown that only allowed citizens to leave their homes to buy essential goods.

Abecasis elaborated on the severity of the situation, recounting how during the pandemic, her children “went almost two years without classes.” “In big cities people could send their kids to private schools, but in smaller towns like

mine education is entirely public.”

Living in Reconquista, a small city 800 kilometers away from Buenos Aires, her experience reflects that of many Argentine citizens.

The pandemic isolated Argentines, not only through social distancing, but also by separating them from their own government. The economic consequences of COVID-19 intensified years of frustration and further amplified demands for change.

For some, the crisis justified greater state intervention to protect citizens, while for others, it exposed the failures of government control and the need for a market-oriented system.

These differing frustrations are longstanding and are known in Argentine politics as “la grieta.”

La grieta refers to the division between left and right-wing political factions in Argentina, so pervasive that it exists not only between political parties, but also within them. For instance, the Justicialists, Argentina's main Peronist movement, have long been characterized by internal divisions. One of the most influential aspects within Peronism is Kirchnerism—a more left-leaning populist current. During Fernández's presidency, Peronism operated as a coalition heavily influenced by Kirchnerist leadership.

As a result, Fernández's alignment with Kirchnerism intensified ideological divisions, reinforcing perception among right-wing citizens that the government was moving further left. This contributed to a deepening of la grieta during the pandemic.

Although the rise of Kirchnerism contributed to this polarization, corruption was the driving force. Former President Fernández was charged with “abuse of authority” and violating a public official's duties for allegedly extending the COVID-19 lockdown between 2020 and 2021 for political gain.

At the same time, many Argentines experienced what they perceived as a breakdown in public services during the pandemic. Abecasis recounts that in her

community, Reconquista, nearly 90% of patients who were intubated with COVID-19 died. She attributes these outcomes to an overwhelmed public healthcare system, unable to respond effectively to the pandemic due to years of government mismanagement.

Not only was Argentina mourning the loss of its loved ones, but it also experienced a severe economic downturn. The inflation rate soared past 100% for the first time since the hyperinflation of the '90s. Citizens couldn't keep up with the cost of living. The price of meat alone rose by almost 20% within a single month.

Rapid inflation meant many Argentines were earning only enough to survive. Every penny spent was directed towards necessities. The dramatic decrease in purchasing power greatly affected the economy. With around 50% of employment in the informal sector, declining disposable income left informal workers with almost no earnings.

The pandemic's consequences left society deeply unsatisfied. Argentine political scientist and Professor at *Universidad Torcuato Di Tella*, Juan Negri, explained in an interview with *The Politic*, "Today, Peronism has become associated with chaos; whenever it looks like they might win, country risk rises, the dollar spikes, and markets become unstable." In turn, financial markets reacted with increased uncertainty and reduced confidence in the country's economic stability. Trust in the government was completely lost, and cit-

"As a minority government without parliamentary support, he needed to rely on public opinion."

izens, more than ever before, desired stability.

Milei understood this evolving social environment. As Negri elaborated, Milei knew that, "as a minority government without parliamentary support, he needed to rely on public opinion."

Abecasis, like many Argentines, quickly found Milei's policies and rhetoric appealing. She recounted how "with Milei, he made us realize that there were things that actually could be done" about Argentina's declining situation.

Milei's campaign centered on his plan to end Argentina's decay. He wanted to create a new Argentina, fundamentally different from the previous left-wing administration. He envisioned a country built instead on free-market principles and liberal values.

Milei's radical capitalist reforms particularly resonated with Argentine youth. The young population's support for Milei was so strong that almost 70% of young

voters backed him in the November 2023 election. Abecasis stated, "What surprised me is how Milei connected with young people through social media, such as TikTok." She added, "He explains economics very clearly,"—a strategy that has helped turn support for him into the norm among young voters.

Although Milei received widespread support from younger audiences, older generations were unaware of this appeal at first. Abecasis recounts how her daughter one day said that Milei is going to win, and she simply responded, "Cata, you're crazy."

When Milei did actually win, his victory surpassed expectations. Milei's party, *La Libertad Avanza*, won nearly 41% of the vote in Argentina's recent legislative elections, marking one of the first times a party has won a midterm election since 2017.

Widespread support can be explained by the sense of order and stability that Milei's new government gave the country. Negri stated, "The government had positive results to show...there was a perception that the future would be better."

In his first year in office, Milei delivered on his promises of security and economic stability. Crime and murder rates fell by more than 50%. Inflation slowed from a monthly rate of 25.5% to 2.7%. Argentina achieved a financial surplus of 0.3% of GDP for the first time since 2006.

Not only did Milei prove himself through meaningful results, but he also used his image strategically, positioning himself as an anti-establishment outsider. He reinforced this persona through provocative rhetoric and symbolic gestures, such as his "chainsaw" proposal to cut government spending. Abecasis emphasized how she "was surprised by how well known he was, Trump supported him, which was unthinkable for an Argentine president before." His reputation only further consolidated initial support in his government.

On paper, the results were clear. However, in society, the situation was much



An employee waits for customers at a produce shop in the San Telmo neighborhood.



Small-scale producers from the Union of Land Workers (UTT) unload a truck of vegetables during the “Verdurazo.” The producers donated 20,000 kilos of vegetables to retirees in front of the National Congress, demanding the passage of a land access law.

more complex.

While Argentina’s economy is improving, it has not translated into the stability many anticipated. Luna Miguens, director of the Land, Housing, and Economic Justice Program at the Center for Legal and Social Studies (CELS), attributed the lack of social stability to Milei’s economic model that generates activity without creating stable, formal employment. In an interview with *The Politic*, she explained that in key sectors, policies implemented “do not create high-quality formal jobs” even if “they do generate some economic activity.”

As a result, much of the workforce is forced to rely on informal labor, where income is irregular and unprotected. Miguens further explained that even traditionally stable groups are affected, as “the lower middle class and informal workers [are] merging into a single highly vulnerable group.”

Milei’s economic policies, even though direct, are harsh. For instance, he reduced public spending by 30%, eliminating de-

partments such as Education, Social Development, and Health, to achieve a budgetary surplus and promote a market-driven economy. These cuts have disproportionately affected lower-income and rural populations who rely heavily on public services. In many regions, especially outside major cities, public institutions are often the primary provider of these services. As a result, reductions in funding and staffing have translated into fewer available resources and reduced access to essential services, placing increasing strain on public health and education systems.

Despite perceptions as a champion of change, Milei’s presidency actively reinforces *la grieta* through his policies and governing style. His reduction of government involvement in the economy has been welcomed by supporters as necessary reform, while critics see it as taking away essential support systems. Abecasis and Miguens’ views on Milei’s economic policies illustrate this divide.

While Abecasis acknowledges that

Milei’s policies can be aggressive, she emphasized how they have shown results so far. She argued, “now salaries are real,” reflecting a shift away from wages distorted by inflation and government intervention. “So, people only hire what they truly need.” She sees this as evidence of a more efficient, even if more restrictive, economy.

Furthermore, Abecasis alluded to the previous government’s corruption, explaining how “many people don’t want change because the system has benefitted them.” Under Milei, however, Argentina’s Corruption Perception index stood at 36 out of 100, its lowest level since 2019.

Miguens offers a far more critical perspective, arguing that Milei’s reforms have come at the expense of social stability. She highlighted how weakened essential support has been notable, noting that “the role the State used to play at least fulfilled those functions to some extent. Today, it no longer does, or it does so in a very limited way.”

Rather than increasing efficiency, she





believes these economic policies have created a growing economic strain for households, particularly the lower and middle classes.

This strain is reflected in survey data from *La Cocina de los Cuidados*, a CELS-led initiative focused on households with caregiving responsibilities, where 42% of respondents said their economic situation worsened over the past year, while 16% stated it had remained equally difficult. Notably, 56% reported having to reduce food consumption due to resource constraints.

Ultimately, such direct contrast in viewpoints reveals that *la grieta* is no longer confined to a purely political divide; it is now a reflection of two competing realities in Argentina. Perceptions of Milei's leadership are not only shaped by ideology, but by materially different lived experiences. As these competing realities continue, public opinion has become increasingly volatile.

At present, Milei has faced some backlash. His administration recently experienced a decline of about 5% in support, and criticism of his government has intensified in recent weeks. This may be partly explained by a decline in negative sentiment toward the previous administration of Alberto Fernández, as public attention shifts towards Milei's own performance.

Negri elaborated how society "can't spend four years blaming the previous government, at some point, society will start holding the current administration accountable." Milei's campaign was built on public opinion, so it is only natural for the party to experience some decrease in its overall support. This shift is also occurring now because the initial period of public patience is fading; people are bearing the costs of Milei's economic reforms in everyday life.

The shift in public opinion reflects the broader uncertainty in the country concerning Milei's reforms. Argentina's long-term success remains conditional on Milei's ability to deliver concrete economic improvements while also accounting for the social costs borne by society as a whole. Negri suggested, "These drastic changes must generate well-being for most of the population relatively quickly or the dynamic changes."

The shift in public opinion reflects an uncertain future for Argentina under Milei's rule. For some, his reforms have provided hope for a desire for economic stability; for others, he signals the erosion of essential social protections. As the consequences of his policies unfold, the question is no longer whether *la grieta* will persist, but what version of Argentina will prevail.

“These drastic changes must generate well-being for most of the population relatively quickly or the dynamic changes.”



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